Julien Clifford

PRINCIPAL SOFTWARE ENGINEER

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Over 15 years building production software. Sole engineer on Atelier Actara, a platform that runs fashion shows, with web, iOS, and Android clients on one GraphQL API. Spent two years at Invisible Technologies delivering to OpenAI, Microsoft, Google, and Amazon, and built the QA function there. Engineers have reported to me at Chess.com, Invisible, and Amplify Life Insurance. Before that, energy and industrial software at Landdox, Quorum, and BSD Consulting.

EXPERIENCE

Atelier Actara

December 2022 to present

Founder and Principal Engineer / Remote

A platform that has run three fashion shows, covering casting, lineup, venues, guest lists, and check-in, built alongside the roles below.

- Designed and built the whole system as the only engineer: an Elixir and Phoenix back end split into domain apps behind one GraphQL API, a React and TypeScript web client, Postgres, and the hosting on Google Cloud and Fly.io.
- Built the multi-tenant permission model that lets agencies, brands, and venues work the same show without seeing each other's data.
- Put native iOS and Android apps and a command-line admin tool on the same API, so the business rules exist in one place.
- Wrote the engineering conventions and skill files that AI coding agents work from, and the checks that run before a change ships, one of which rejects copy that reads as machine-written.
- Set the pricing, wrote the financial plan, and designed the brand and the design system the product ships with.

Chess.com

June 2025 to April 2026

Technical Product Manager / Remote

- Wrote the specs engineers built from, refining loose product requirements into scoped, estimated work.
- Led two engineering teams through the new-player onboarding work, from spec to release, for millions of new players.
- Added the onboarding and activation metrics the team uses to judge funnel changes.
- Built the configuration layer that varies onboarding per player, choosing the steps a new player sees from that player's details, and runs experiments on those variations.
- Managed three engineers and owned the new-user experience roadmap and release plan.

Invisible Technologies

March 2023 to February 2025

Principal Engineer and Partner / Remote

An AI services company delivering to OpenAI, Microsoft, Google, and Amazon.

- Built the QA function: testing standards, documentation, and an automated suite that took coverage from zero to 85 percent.
- Designed and built the terms of service and statement of work system, with the data model and rules for the contracts behind each client engagement, and in-app time tracking against those agreements.
- Managed two engineering teams in parallel, four engineers reporting to me, owning delivery, hiring, and performance for both.
- Ran technical hiring, sourcing externally and promoting engineers from inside the company.
- Worked in Python, Django, and Flask across the services behind the client work.

Amplify Life Insurance

September 2021 to June 2022

Staff Engineer / Remote

A life insurer building a first engineering team and software stack.

- Replaced the legacy stack with a company-wide API server and Postgres database in Elixir, with continuous integration and tests from the first commit.
- Built the React and Redux front ends against the new API.
- Defined the code review policy the engineering team used, and reviewed both front end and back end.
- Managed three engineers, and ran sprint planning, scoping, and retrospectives for the team.

Vic.ai

June 2021 to September 2021

Senior Elixir Engineer / Remote

- Shipped core Elixir for an early-stage startup, including a CSV importer that handled arbitrary client file formats, and introduced retrospectives, documentation, and project planning.

Quorum Software

October 2020 to May 2021

Senior Software Engineer / Houston, Texas

Enterprise software for the energy industry.

- Integrated the Landdox product into Quorum's enterprise legacy codebase after the acquisition.

Landdox

June 2015 to October 2020

Full Stack Engineer, second engineer hired / Houston, Texas

Land management software for oil and gas, acquired by Quorum Software in 2020.

- Planned and led the major features: mapping, bulk data import, and a system that generated payment checks.
- Worked across the full stack and the infrastructure: Elixir, Node, Angular, React, AWS, and Terraform.
- Interviewed and hired engineers, and joined sales calls to answer technical questions.

EARLIER

BSD Consulting / Full Stack Engineer 2014 to 2015

Sole engineer on a web platform for pipeline data, server and client, from prototype through delivery.

Conrad Blucher Institute / Undergraduate Research Assistant 2010 to 2014

Built mobile mapping applications for land surveying, funded in part by NOAA, including survey-grade GPS and RTK field collection.

Esri and Shell Oil Company / Technical Marketing and Geomatics internships 2012 and 2013

Wrote geoprocessing scripts supporting disaster response at Esri, and Python automation for spatial data pipelines and raster generation from raw sonar at Shell, plus seven days at sea on a hydrographic survey.

TECHNICAL

BACKEND	Elixir and Phoenix, OTP, Absinthe GraphQL, Ecto, Python, Django, Flask, Node, PHP
FRONTEND	React, Redux, React Router, Angular, TypeScript, MUI, Tailwind
DATA	PostgreSQL, SQL
PLATFORM	AWS, Google Cloud, Terraform, Docker, Fly.io, CI and CD pipelines
ARCHITECTURE	Multi-tenant systems, GraphQL API design, one API behind web, iOS, and Android clients
DELIVERY	Scrum and sprint planning, release planning, code review standards, test automation (ExUnit, Playwright, Vitest), technical hiring
AI ENABLEMENT	AI-assisted development standards, written engineering conventions, agent skill definitions, automated verification gates

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EDUCATION

Texas A&M University, Corpus Christi 2009 to 2014

Bachelor of Science, Geographic Information Science and Geomatics